“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Antya-līlā

Chapter 17

# Śrī Caitanya in the Form of a Tortoise

*(translated from the Bengali for this edition)*

**1** Having heard it from the mouths of those who saw it with their own eyes, I describe the most wonderful, unearthly conduct of Śrīla Gauracandra in His divine madness.

**2** Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra, and glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

**3** In this way, night and day, Mahāprabhu, absorbed in love, behaved like one mad and spoke in ravings.

**4** One day the Lord passed half the night with Svarūpa and Rāmānanda, delighting in talks about Kṛṣṇa.

**5** Whenever some feeling arose in the Lord, Svarūpa Mahāśaya would sing a song suited to that feeling.

**6** And Rāya Rāmānanda would recite verses from Vidyāpati, Caṇḍīdāsa and the *Śrī Gīta-govinda* suited to His feelings.

**7** Now and then the Lord would Himself recite a verse and explain its meaning, lamenting.

**8** In this way, in various feelings, half the night passed. Then, after putting the Lord to bed, the two of them went home.

**9** Govinda lay down to sleep at the door of the Gambhīrā, and at midnight the Lord began loud *saṅkīrtana*.

**10** Suddenly the Lord heard the song of Kṛṣṇa's flute and, absorbed in feeling, set off towards it.

**11** The panels of the three doors remained fastened as they were, yet, absorbed in feeling, the Lord went out.

**12** To the south of the Siṁha-dvāra there was a herd of cows from Tailaṅga. Going there, the Lord fell unconscious.

**13** Meanwhile Govinda, no longer hearing any sound from Mahāprabhu, opened the doors and called Svarūpa.

**14** Then Svarūpa Gosāñi took the devotees with him, and they lit torches and searched for the Lord.

**15** After searching here and there, they went to the Siṁha-dvāra and found the Lord among the cows.

**16** His hands and feet had drawn inside His body, and He had the shape of a tortoise. There was foam at His mouth, the hair of His body stood on end, and tears streamed from His eyes.

**17** He lay unconscious, like a great pumpkin: outwardly inert, but within overwhelmed with bliss.

**18** On every side the cows were sniffing the Lord's holy body; even when driven away, they would not leave His side.

**19** The devotees tried hard to revive Him, but He did not regain consciousness. Then they lifted the Lord and carried Him home.

**20** They sang the holy name loudly into His ears, and after a long while Mahāprabhu regained consciousness.

**21** When He came to Himself, His hands and feet came out again, and His body became as it had been, in its proper proportions.

**22** The Lord got up, sat, and looked about Him. He said to Svarūpa, “Where have you brought Me?

**23** Hearing the sound of the flute, I went to Vṛndāvana, and I saw the son of the king of Vraja playing His flute in the pasture.

**24** At the signal call of His flute, Rādhā went to the bower, and Kṛṣṇa too went to the bower to enjoy His pastimes.

**25** I followed close behind Him, and the jingling of His ornaments captivated My ears.

**26** He sported with the *gopīs*, laughing and jesting, and My ears rejoiced to hear the sound of His voice and His words.

**27** Just then all of you raised an uproar and brought Me here by force.

**28** I could not hear those words like nectar; I could not hear the sound of His ornaments and His flute.”

**29** Absorbed in feeling, the Lord said to Svarūpa in a choked voice, “My ears are dying of thirst. Recite something full of the nectar of *rasa* — let Me hear it.”

**30** Svarūpa Gosāñi, knowing the Lord's mood, sweetly recited a verse from the *Bhāgavata*:

**31** "O Kṛṣṇa, what woman in the three worlds, enchanted by the song of Your flute with its sweet, nectarean notes, would not stray from the conduct of the noble? Seeing this form of Yours, the beauty of the three worlds, even cows, birds, trees and deer bristle with rapture." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.29.40)

**32** Hearing this, the Lord became absorbed in the mood of the *gopīs* and began to explain the meaning of the verse:

**33** Absorbed in the mood of the *gopīs*, He entered the *rāsa* dance. Hearing Kṛṣṇa's words of disregard and taking His smiling, playful words as a true rejection, He reproached Kṛṣṇa in anger:

**34** "O lover, tell us truly: of all the worthy women who fill the three worlds, which is not drawn by Your flute?

**35** You sent the sound of Your flute into the world, and like a *yoginī* perfect in her mantras, it becomes a go-between and enchants the minds of women. It swells their longing, makes them leave the path of the noble, and brings them and gives them up to You.

**36** With Your flute You make us abandon *dharma*; You strike us with the arrows of Kāma, Your sidelong glances, and make us cast off shame and fear and everything else. And now You are angry with us, You say it is a fault to leave our husbands, and, turned righteous, You teach us *dharma*!

**37** Your words say one thing, Your mind another, and outwardly You act in yet another way — all these are the artifices of a cheat. For You it is only a jest, but for women it is utter ruin. Give up all these tricks!

**38** The sound of Your flute outdoes nectar; Your sweet words are like nectar, and the jingling of Your ornaments is like nectar too. With these three nectars You steal our ears, You steal our minds, You steal our very life. How can a woman keep hold of her heart?"[1]

**39** Having said this in anger, He floated on the waves of feeling, and His mind sank into an ocean of longing. Then He recited Rādhā's words of longing and, explaining them Himself, tasted the sweetness of Kṛṣṇa:

**40** "O friend, His voice is like the rumbling of a thundering cloud; the lovely jingling of His ornaments draws the ears; the artful turns of His speech — its syllables, words and meanings — all hint at the *rasa* of jest; and the soft note of His flute steals the hearts of Lakṣmī and the other fairest of women. That Madana-mohana increases the longing of My ears." (Govinda-līlāmṛta, 8.5)

**41** "The deep sound of His voice conquers the rumbling of a new cloud, and its sweetness puts the cuckoo to shame. Even a single drop of it, entering the ear, drowns the ears of the world, and those ears never come back again.

**42** Tell Me, friend, what shall I do? The charms of that sound of Kṛṣṇa's stole My ears, and now, not getting it, they are dying of thirst.

**43** The sound of the bells on His ankles and waist conquers the cries of swans and cranes, and the jingling of His bracelets puts the *caṭaka* birds to shame. Whoever hears it even once, it fills his ears and stays there, and no other sound enters those ears again.

**44** The words of His holy mouth are a nectar higher than nectar, and the camphor of His smile is mixed into them. Their two powers, sound and meaning, bring out every kind of *rasa*, and every syllable is adorned with jest.

**45** One drop of that nectar is the very life of the *cakora* bird of the ears, and on the hope of it alone that *cakora* lives. Sometimes by good fortune it gets that drop, sometimes by misfortune it does not, and when it does not, it dies of thirst.

**46** As for the sweet sound of His flute — hearing it but once, the hearts of the women of the world are thrown into turmoil. The knots of their sashes slip loose; they become His maidservants without price and, as if crazed, run to Kṛṣṇa's side.

**47** Even the goddess Lakṣmī, hearing that soft song, comes to Kṛṣṇa in hope. But she does not obtain Kṛṣṇa's company; the waves of her thirst only swell, and though she performs austerities, she still does not obtain Him.

**48** Only one whose fortune is great drinks these four nectars of sound with his ears. As for one who does not hear them — why were such ears ever born? They are no better than a cracked cowrie shell."

**49** As He lamented in this way, agitation and other feelings arose in Him, and His mind had nothing to hold on to. Agitation, despondency, resolve, eagerness, fear, steadiness and remembrance — many feelings met together in Him.

**50** Rādhā's words in such a mixture of feelings had been revealed to Līlāśuka. In that same feeling the Lord recited one of his verses and, by the power of His madness, drew out a meaning that people do not know:

**51** "What shall we do now? To whom shall we speak? What was done in hope is done. Talk of something else, something auspicious. Alas! He lies in My heart. For Kṛṣṇa — the festival of mind and eyes, whose smiling form is sweeter than the sweetest — My wretched, most wretched thirst, alas, only grows longer." (Kṛṣṇa-karṇāmṛta, 42)

**52** “In this separation from Kṛṣṇa My mind is so agitated that it cannot be still, and I cannot think how to attain Him. And you, My friends — your minds too are crazed with despondency. Whom shall I ask? Who will tell Me the way?

**53** Alas, alas, friend, what shall I do? What shall I do, where shall I go? Where must I go to find Kṛṣṇa? Without Kṛṣṇa My life is leaving Me.”

**54** For a moment His mind became steady, and He reflected. As He spoke, a new feeling arose: the remembrance of Piṅgalā’s words brought Him to a resolve, and by it He determined the meaning of the verse:

**55** “I see only this way: I will give up My hope for Kṛṣṇa. When hope is given up, the mind becomes happy. Leave this inauspicious talk of Kṛṣṇa and speak of something else, something auspicious, so that Kṛṣṇa may be forgotten.”

**56** But even as She said this, She remembered Him, and Kṛṣṇa appeared in Her heart. Astonished, She said to Her friend, “He whom I want to give up is lying in My heart. I cannot give Him up by any means.”

**57** Such is the wondrous nature of Rādhā’s feeling that it made Her see Kṛṣṇa as Kāma himself, and seeing Him so, Her heart was filled with fear. She said, “He who strikes down the whole world has entered My heart. This enemy will not let Me forget Him.”

**58** Then eagerness, conquering the armies of all the other feelings, rose to supremacy in its own kingdom, Her mind. A craving arose in Her mind that She could not control, and in sorrow She reproached Her mind:

**59** “My mind is contrary and wretched. Like a fish without water, without Kṛṣṇa it is dying at every moment. And Kṛṣṇa’s sweetly smiling face, the elixir of mind and eyes, makes My thirst for Him twice as great.

**60** Alas, Kṛṣṇa, treasure of My life! Alas, lotus-eyed one! Alas, divine ocean of virtues! Alas, Śyāmasundara! Alas, You who wear yellow cloth! Alas, lover who sports in the *rāsa* dance!

**61** Where must I go to find You? Tell Me, and I will go there!" Saying this, the Lord ran off. But Svarūpa rose, took Him in his arms, brought Him back holding Him, and seated Him in His own place.

**62** In a moment the Lord came back to outer consciousness and said to Svarūpa, "Svarūpa, sing something sweet." Svarūpa sang songs of Vidyāpati and of the *Gīta-govinda*, and hearing them, the Lord's ears were soothed.

**63** In this way, every night and day, Mahāprabhu behaved as one mad and spoke in ravings.

**64** Even if one with a thousand mouths were to describe all the transformations of feeling that arose in Him in a single day, he could not reach their end.

**65** What can a lowly *jīva* like me describe of it? As one shows the moon by pointing to a branch, I give only an indication.

**66** Whoever hears this, his mind and ears are soothed, and he comes to know the unearthly workings of secret love.

**67** The Lord Himself tasted the wonderful glory of the sweetness of most secret love and showed its utmost limit.

**68** Wonderfully merciful is Caitanya, wonderfully generous! We hear of no other giver in the world so merciful.

**69** O people, worship the feet of Caitanya with all your heart! From them you will receive the treasure of the nectar of love for Kṛṣṇa.

**70** Thus I have told of the Lord's state in the form of a tortoise, and of His behaviour and ravings in that divine madness.

**71** Raghunātha dāsa has described this pastime in his own book, the *Caitanya-stava-kalpavṛkṣa*:

**72** "Ah! Without opening the three doors, He passed high over the three tall walls and fell among the cows of Kaliṅga. Through His great separation from Kṛṣṇa His body contracted, and He appeared like a tortoise. That Gaurāṅga, rising in my heart, makes me mad with joy." (Caitanya-stava-kalpavṛkṣa, 5)

**73** Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

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**Notes**

1. So according to the *Anubhāṣya*: *amṛta-ghole*, from the idiom *ghola khāoyāya*, "makes [it] drink buttermilk", that is, outdoes, overpowers nectar. The *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya* understands it differently: "the sound of the flute is nectarean buttermilk." ↩